

THE STONE AGE: PALAEOLITHIC & MESOLITHIC

STONE AGE CHRONOLOGICAL-CLIMATIC SPINE → STONE IS A BEHAVIOURAL → LITHIC SYSTEMS COMPARED → INDIAN SITE MAP: REGION → MOBILITY-SUBSISTENCE-SOCIAL LOOP → ROCK ART AND SYMBOLIC

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure: the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE + Pending user review + source generation g10 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA + prior artefacts unchanged + exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00

STONE AGE CHRONOLOGICAL-CLIMATIC SPINE

STONE AGE CHRONOLOGICAL-CLIMATIC SPINEPLEISTOCENE HOLOCENELOWER PALAEOLITHICMIDDLE PALAEOLITHICUPPER PALAEOLITHICMESOLITHIC HANDAXE/CLEAVER FLAKES/PREPARED CORES BLADES/BONE/ART MICROLITHS MOBILE LANDSCAPES FLEXIBLE

TRANSITIONS ARE REGIONALLY STAGGERED; TOOL CHANGE IS NOT A

PLEISTOCENE HOLOCENE

Lower Palaeolithic → Middle Palaeolithic → Upper Palaeolithic → Mesolithic handaxe/cleaver flakes/prepared cores blades/bone/art microliths

reduction wider symbolism diverse niches

Transitions are regionally staggered; tool change is not a single species timetable.

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

PLEISTOCENE HOLOCENE
Lower Palaeolithic → Middle Palaeolithic → Upper Palaeolithic → Mesolithic handaxe/cleaver flakes/prepared cores blades/bone/art microliths mobile landscapes flexible

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

reduction wider symbolism diverse niches
Transitions are regionally staggered; tool change is not a single species timetable.

IMPACT / LIMIT

PLEISTOCENE HOLOCENE
Lower Palaeolithic → Middle Palaeolithic → Upper Palaeolithic → Mesolithic handaxe/cleaver flakes/prepared cores blades/bone/art microliths mobile landscapes flexible

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Transitions are regionally staggered; tool change is not a single species timetable.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Transitions are regionally staggered; tool change is not a single species timetable.

01

STAGE 01

STONE IS A BEHAVIOURAL ARCHIVE

STONE IS A BEHAVIOURAL ARCHIVERAW-MATERIAL NODULECORE REDUCTIONTOOL USEDISCARD SOURCE DISTANCE SKILL/PLANNING EDGE DAMAGE ACTIVITY AREAASSEMBLAGE + STRATIGRAPHY + DATING + PALAEOENVIRONMENTBEHAVIOURAL INFERENCE

A LABELLED TOOL WITHOUT CONTEXT CANNOT ESTABLISH AGE, SPECIES

RAW-MATERIAL NODULE → CORE REDUCTION → FLAKE/BLADE → TOOL USE → DISCARD source distance skill/planning

ASSEMBLAGE + STRATIGRAPHY + DATING + PALAEOENVIRONMENT → BEHAVIOURAL INFERENCE

A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

RAW-MATERIAL NODULE → CORE REDUCTION → FLAKE/BLADE → TOOL USE → DISCARD source distance skill/planning edge damage activity area
ASSEMBLAGE + STRATIGRAPHY + DATING + PALAEOENVIRONMENT → BEHAVIOURAL INFERENCE

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.
RAW-MATERIAL NODULE → CORE REDUCTION → FLAKE/BLADE → TOOL USE → DISCARD source distance skill/planning edge damage activity area

DEBATE / LEGACY

ASSEMBLAGE + STRATIGRAPHY + DATING + PALAEOENVIRONMENT → BEHAVIOURAL INFERENCE
A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.

02

STAGE 02

LITHIC SYSTEMS COMPARED

LITHIC SYSTEMS COMPAREDLLOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC BIFACES, CLEAVERS FLAKE TOOLS BLADESTECHNOLOGY RECORDS CHOICES; OLDER TECHNIQUES MAY PERSIST BESIDE NEWERGROWTH HAFTED COMPOSITES QUARTZITE COMMON RAW-MATERIAL ECONOMY SYMBOLIC EVIDENCE

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
LOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC bifaces, cleavers flake tools blades, burins geometric microliths large cutting tools prepared-core planning bone/ornament	Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.	growth hafted composites quartzite common raw-material economy symbolic evidence bow/sickle/barb uses
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POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

LOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC bifaces, cleavers flake tools blades, burins geometric microliths large cutting tools prepared-core planning bone/ornament
growth hafted composites quartzite common raw-material economy symbolic evidence bow/sickle/barb uses

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.
LOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC bifaces, cleavers flake tools blades, burins geometric microliths large cutting tools prepared-core planning bone/ornament

DEBATE / LEGACY

growth hafted composites quartzite common raw-material economy symbolic evidence bow/sickle/barb uses
Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.

03

STAGE 03

INDIAN SITE MAP: REGION, SITE, SIGNIFICANCE

INDIAN SITE MAPREGION, SITE, SIGNIFICANCESOAN VALLEYRIVER-TERRACE LITHICS AND SEQUENCE DEBATESBELAN VALLEYLONG PREHISTORIC SEQUENCE TOWARD FOOD PRODUCTIONSHELTERS/ROCK ARTMESOLITHIC EVIDENCE

NORTH-WEST: Soan valley → river-terrace lithics and sequence debates

NORTH: Belan valley → long prehistoric sequence toward food production

CENTRAL: Bhimbetka → shelters/rock art

Adamgarh → Mesolithic evidence

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

NORTH-WEST: Soan valley → river-terrace lithics and sequence debates
NORTH: Belan valley → long prehistoric sequence toward food production
CENTRAL: Bhimbetka → shelters/rock art

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Adamgarh → Mesolithic evidence
WEST: Bagor → Mesolithic settlement: subsistence and domestication debate
GANGA PLAIN: Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha, Damdama → burials and sedentism

DEBATE / LEGACY

SOUTH: Attirampakkam → early Acheulian and Middle Palaeolithic chronology
DECCAN: Hunsgi-Baichbal → quarry, factory and landscape organisation

MECHANISM / VERDICT — DECCAN: Hunsgi-Baichbal → quarry, factory and landscape organisation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DECCAN: Hunsgi-Baichbal → quarry, factory and landscape organisation.

04

STAGE 04

MOBILITY-SUBSISTENCE-SOCIAL LOOP

MOBILITY-SUBSISTENCE-SOCIAL LOOPSEASONAL RESOURCESMOVEMENT SCHEDULECAMP TYPECAMP TYPEKITSHARING NETWORK GAME, FISH, PLANTS BASE/SPECIAL CAMP HEARTH'S PORTABLE/COMPOSITE

REPEATED OCCUPATION AND STORAGE MAY INCREASE WITHOUT FULL FARMING

BURIALS SHOW TREATMENT OF PERSONS; RANK NEEDS PATTERNED UNEQUAL

SEASONAL RESOURCES → MOVEMENT SCHEDULE → CAMP TYPE → TOOL KIT → SHARING NETWORK game

Repeated occupation and storage may increase without full farming or permanent villages.

Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

SEASONAL RESOURCES → MOVEMENT SCHEDULE → CAMP TYPE → TOOL KIT → SHARING NETWORK game, fish, plants base/special camp hearth's portable/composite
Repeated occupation and storage may increase without full farming or permanent villages.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.
SEASONAL RESOURCES → MOVEMENT SCHEDULE → CAMP TYPE → TOOL KIT → SHARING NETWORK game, fish, plants base/special camp hearth's portable/composite

DEBATE / LEGACY

Repeated occupation and storage may increase without full farming or permanent villages.
Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.

05

STAGE 05

ROCK ART AND SYMBOLIC LIFE: INFERENCE LADDER

ROCK ART AND SYMBOLIC LIFEINFERENCE LADDERPIGMENT/ENGRAVING + SUPERIMPOSITION + MOTIF + SHELTER CONTEXT SECUREIMAGE, TECHNIQUE, RELATIVE SEQUENCE AND DEMONSTRATED ASSOCIATION PROBABLEHUNTING, DANCE, GROUP ACTION, ANIMALS AND CHANGING STYLE UNCERTAIN

EXACT MYTH, DEITY, ARTIST IDENTITY OR DIRECT RITUAL MEANINGART EXPANDS BEHAVIOURAL EVIDENCE BUT IS NOT ILLUSTRATED SCRIPTURE.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

PIGMENT/ENGRAVING + SUPERIMPOSITION + MOTIF + SHELTER CONTEXT secure: image, technique, relative sequence and demonstrated association probable: hunting.
dance, group action, animals and changing style uncertain: exact myth, deity, artist identity or direct ritual meaning

METHOD / DEBATE

VERDICT: art expands behavioural evidence but is not illustrated scripture.
PIGMENT/ENGRAVING + SUPERIMPOSITION + MOTIF + SHELTER CONTEXT secure: image, technique, relative sequence and demonstrated association probable: hunting.

HISTORICAL RESULT

dance, group action, animals and changing style uncertain: exact myth, deity, artist identity or direct ritual meaning
VERDICT: art expands behavioural evidence but is not illustrated scripture.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: art expands behavioural evidence but is not illustrated scripture.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: art expands behavioural evidence but is not illustrated scripture.

06

STAGE 06

MESOLITHIC TRANSITION: ADAPTATION, NOT REVOLUTION

MESOLITHIC TRANSITIONADAPTATION, NOT REVOLUTIONHOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES SMALL GAME/FISH/PLANT NICHES +UNEVEN PATHWAYS TOWARD NEOLITHIC PRODUCTION

HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools seasonal

selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps
selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps
selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production

DEBATE / LEGACY

HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps
selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production

MECHANISM / VERDICT — HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production.

07

STAGE 07

LIMITS AND CURRENT RESEARCH

LIMITS AND CURRENT RESEARCHSPARSE FOSSILS + DISTURBED SITES + BROAD TOOL LABELSFALSE SHORTCUTSONE TOOLONE PEOPLEDATE CONTEXTS, RECONSTRUCT REDUCTION SEQUENCE, COMPARE REGIONS, STATE CONFIDENCE

REFINED CHRONOMETRY AND LANDSCAPE STUDY CAN REVISE EARLY DATESINDIAN PREHISTORY IS A MOSAIC OF LONG CONTINUITY AND

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

PROBLEM: sparse fossils + disturbed sites + broad tool labels + uncertain associations
FALSE SHORTCUTS: one tool = one people
innovation = migration

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

burial = hierarchy
RESPONSE: date contexts, reconstruct reduction sequence, compare regions, state confidence
Refined chronometry and landscape study can revise early dates.

DEBATE / LEGACY

VERDICT: Indian prehistory is a mosaic of long continuity and episodic innovation.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Indian prehistory is a mosaic of long continuity and episodic innovation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Indian prehistory is a mosaic of long continuity and episodic innovation.

08

STAGE 08

STONE AGE ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

STONE AGE ANSWER ARCHITECTURE10 MARKSDEFINE PHASEDIAGNOSTIC TECHNOLOGYTWO SITES15 MARKSLITHIC COMPARISONSYMBOLIC EVIDENCE

10 MARKS: define phase → diagnostic technology → two sites → subsistence → caution

15 MARKS: chronology → lithic comparison → ecology/mobility → symbolic evidence → limits

20 MARKS: geological frame → methods → four-stage technology → regional site map

economy/social life → Mesolithic transition → historiographical verdict

MUST DISTINGUISH: relative/absolute date; artefact/assembly; microlith/sedentism.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

10 MARKS: define phase → diagnostic technology → two sites → subsistence → caution
15 MARKS: chronology → lithic comparison → ecology/mobility → symbolic evidence → limits

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

20 MARKS: geological frame → methods → four-stage technology → regional site map
economy/social life → Mesolithic transition → historiographical verdict

DEBATE / LEGACY

MUST DISTINGUISH: relative/absolute date; artefact/assembly; microlith/sedentism.
CLOSE: technology records adaptive choices, not a uniform evolutionary ladder.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — economy/social life → Mesolithic transition → historiographical verdict

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: economy/social life → Mesolithic transition → historiographical verdict.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA2. KEY CLASSIFICATION3. STUDY LINKS4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS)5. UPSC TRAPS6. CURRENT LINK7. MAINS ANGLES

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

Mini-timeline
1. Snapshot & core idea
2. Key classification / data
3. Study links

ADVANCED DEBATE

4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
5. UPSC Traps
6. Current link
7. Mains angles

LEGACY / NUANCE

She discusses Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic sites separately, including tool types and manufacturing contexts.
Isampur is treated as a centre of stone-tool manufacture.
Middle Palaeolithic discussions include Attirampakkam and the Levallois technique.
Mesolithic levels can yield animal bones and pottery: some claims of domesticated cattle, sheep, goat, dog and pig are questioned.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.